

J.H. Venter at 70



Johannes Hendrik (Hennie) Venter was born in Johannesburg on 17 April 1938. He is without doubt one of the most outstanding statisticians that South Africa has yet produced.

After high school he entered Potchefstroom University (now Northwest University), registering for a BSc degree in physics with the aim of becoming a nuclear physicist, very much the fashion in those days amongst aspiring scientists. Fortunately, in his second year the University started offering Theory of Statistics as a major subject, which he then read as an additional subject for his degree. After completing his honours degree in mathematics, he was offered a position in the statistics department and this made him switch to statistics for his MSc. Since there was not much expertise at Potchefstroom, he had to work through some advanced books, mostly on his own. This did have the positive effect that he had to figure things out for himself, laying the foundation for his exceptional research ability.

After completing his MSc, Hennie received a grant to study at the University of Chicago. One of the reasons for their interest in this “unknown student” from an “unknown department” was a number of “research reports” that he had sent together with his application. These reports consisted of a number of self-formulated research problems (in mathematics) that he had been working on since an undergraduate, together with solutions that he had written up for himself over the years. Arriving in Chicago, he realised that he had an extremely thin basis in statistics, but fortunately he had an ability to work on his own and had already developed a skill at research. All of this led to him obtaining an MSc as well as a PhD in a period of 2 years, an exceptional feat for someone with such a meagre technical background in statistics. During these 2 years he took courses with such well-known persons as Kruskal, Bahadur, Billingsley, Meier and Goodman. His thesis was on Stochastic Approximation, which was a very hot topic at the time. His thesis advisor was R. R. Bahadur who had suggested the topic. However, in typical Venter style, Hennie did the work very much on his own. After graduating he spent a year at Stanford

University as Assistant Professor, but then decided to return to South Africa in spite of lucrative offers in the US, including one from Chicago.

Returning to Potchefstroom, he spent the next 35 years until his retirement in 1998 building up the Department of Statistics through a steady stream of students and a very substantial stream of outstanding publications. These publications have appeared in some of the most prestigious statistical journals. Since his retirement, he has been employed as a full-time consultant by the Centre for Business Mathematics and Informatics of Northwest University, working in the field of financial statistics which was relatively new to him. Soon, however, he started making high quality practical and theoretical research contributions to this field.

Hennie Venter played a leading role in the founding years of the South African Statistical Journal (SASJ). His paper entitled “Probability Measures on Product Spaces” was the first paper in the first issue of the journal in 1967. He served on the editorial board of the Journal from 1967 to 1971 and then as Editor from 1972 to 1974. He was always extremely generous in publishing some of his highest quality work in SASJ, especially during its early years.

Apart from his involvement in research and training students, Hennie played a leading role in the wider statistical community. He served as President of SASA in 1970 and on the advisory committees of the CSIR, FRD and Central Statistical Service. Acknowledgement of his contributions came through the awarding of the Herbert Sichel Medal in 1997 and 2005, election as fellow and honorary member of SASA, receiving of the Havenga gold medal for Mathematics in 1988 and the MT Steyn gold medal for the advancement of science in 1999, both from the “Suid Afrikaanse Akademie vir Wetenskap en Kuns”.

Hennie Venter has made outstanding and extremely original contributions to the theory and practice of statistics. But above all, in spite of his exceptional mathematical and statistical talents, his greatest contribution was and still is his willingness always to share his ideas, insight and knowledge with his co-workers, colleagues and students.

At 70 he is still academically very active and his creative abilities remain undiminished. We wish him many more such years.